

Why does AWS separate security groups and NACLs?

For defense-in-depth and intentionality. NACLs handle broad, stateless filtering at the subnet level. Security Groups are for fine-grained, stateful filtering at the instance.

Why can't you delete a VPC with resources still in it?

Resource dependency. Just like when you're about to shut down a server and it asks for confirmation to do so, same methodology applies here.

Why is a NAT Gateway expensive?

Because it is a premium managed service by AWS. Data processing charges are what consume a majority of the costs and cloud providers charge a premium for all data that passes through the managed service.